

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Gangster, crime

DIRECTOR

Fernando Meirelles

WRITERS

Bráulio Mantovani
(screenplay); **Paulo Lins**
(novel)

STARS

Alexandre Rodrigues,
Leandro Firmino,
Alice Braga

BEFORE

1990 Martin Scorsese's *Goodfellas* tells the story of the Mafia from the point of view of mobster-turned-informant Henry Hill.

AFTER

2005 Meirelles's Hollywood debut, *The Constant Gardener*, is a love story set in Kenya.**2008** *Blindness*, Meirelles's movie about an epidemic of blindness in an unnamed city, receives mixed reviews.

Stylish, compelling, and hugely entertaining, Fernando Meirelles' *City of God* (*Cidade de Deus*) also has a serious point to make. Told from the perspective of Rocket (Alexandre Rodrigues), an aspiring photographer, it is a movie about one of Brazil's most notorious and impoverished favelas, the Cidade

de Deus in Rio de Janeiro, and how organized crime there corrupted, and, in many cases, destroyed its local youth. Yet Meirelles does not lecture his audience. Instead, he uses every stylistic trick in the cinematic book, from inventive montages to adventurous camera work, to ensure the story is vividly and energetically realized, and engages the audience with the human tragedy.

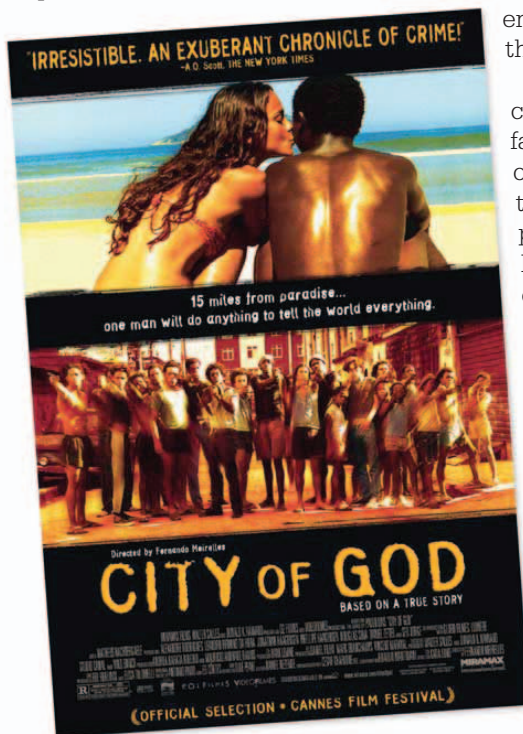
In one scene, a gang of children walks through the favela, joking about taking over the slum and the people they would need to kill in the process. It is darkly humorous but also horrifying to see children bred into violence from so young an age.

Tale of a city

The movie's action is played out at an ambitious scale. Its story spans more than a decade and charts the

Most of the movie's

actors were inhabitants of the favelas portrayed in the movie. Several went on to appear in Meirelles' sequel, *City of Men*.

**Fernando Meirelles** Director

Born to a middle-class family in São Paulo, Brazil, in 1955, Fernando Meirelles studied architecture before winning several awards at Brazilian film festivals with his early shorts. He went on to find success in Brazilian television, most notably the children's show *Rá-Tim Bum*. His first feature was a children's movie, *The Nutty Boy 2* in 1998. He made his name nationally in 2001 with the comedy *Maids*, and internationally a year later with

City of God, which earned him an Oscar nomination for Best Director. Since then, he had further critical successes with *The Constant Gardener* and *Blindness*, for which he was nominated for the Palme d'Or.

Key movies

2001 *Maids*
2002 *City of God*
2005 *The Constant Gardener*
2008 *Blindness*